repeatedly taken the government to court over its attempts to curtail civil liberties in the determined pursuit of its social and economic goals (pending an election, without the legitimacy of a democratic mandate). For their part, the courts had vigorously upheld the new constitutional provisions.

In Delhi, the government's attempt to censor *The Organiser*, an RSS newspaper, had been countermanded.[19] In Bombay, the government's order banning *Cross Roads*, a left-leaning weekly critical of Nehru and the Congress government, had been quashed.[20] In Punjab, while releasing the Akali leader and Nehru baiter Tara Singh, who had been clapped in jail for sedition, the high court had taken the opportunity for reiterating that Section 124A of the Indian Penal Code[21] was wholly unconstitutional and void.[22] By delineating strict limits to governmental interference with the freedom of speech, the judiciary had come out decisively in favour of individual liberty – the government's powers to control public discourse, muffle critical voices and curtail the freedom of the press were eviscerated. As a frustrated Sardar Patel wrote to Nehru, the bottom had been knocked out from penal laws for control and regulation of the press.[23]

Land reform had been stalled. In Uttar Pradesh, the Allahabad High Court had passed a series of injunctions restraining the government from taking any action under the newly passed Zamindari Abolition and Land Reform Act while it examined its constitutional validity. In Bihar, the Land Reform Act had been declared ultra vires of the Constitution by the Patna High Court, for violating Article 14 (the right to equality) by prescribing differential rates of compensation for different landholders.[24] Delivering its verdict in March 1951, the Patna High Court mounted a searing critique of the Congress party and the Bihar government, calling the Act 'an unconstitutional law enacted in the belief that the right of the plaintiffs to challenge it and ask for relief from its operation has been taken away'.[25] The most essential pillar of Congress policy, an article of faith for Nehru and a vital element of the Congress-directed road to socialism, stood in danger of crumbling.